trucks, shouting, “We are leaving! We are leaving!” On November 11, a second massive convoy departed, carrying military battalions and government ministers. This move, probably influenced by astrologers and extreme paranoia, was a shock to nearly everyone in the country. Government officials were given two days notice.

The massive construction of the new capital cost billions of dollars. The location was in a remote malaria-infested area in central Myanmar near the town of Pyinmana. Than Shwe called the capital Naypyidaw, meaning “seat of kings.” Foreign diplomats were informed of the move several days after it occurred. A simple fax number was given to the diplomats if they needed to reach the government. Members of the civil service within Myanmar were also frustrated and angered over such an irrational move. Even for a regime that tended to gravitate toward the bizarre, this was considered extreme. The isolationist's tendencies of the regime were increasing.

Discussions about relocation of the capital or at least some of the administrative components of the state were informally discussed as early as 1998. The initial idea, however, was simply to move the military headquarters to a different location and not the entire administrative structure. This proposed move was meant to clearly separate the military and civilian components of the state. The move was to coincide with the completion of the national convention. When General Khin Nyunt was removed from his position in the government, the decision to relocate the entire apparatus was apparently made.

Several possible factors played into the decision. First, the regime felt that Rangoon was a security threat from both internal and external forces. Internally, the regime feared a repeat of the 1988 protests, which under the right circumstances could bring down the government. Externally, there was growing fear that an international force or an American invasion was within the realm of possibility. The new location was supposedly more secure and fortifiable. The regime had developed an intricate series of tunnels and “rat holes” to secure the leadership in case of invasion. Second, Rangoon was an aging city with infrastructural problems. The regime may have decided that the refurbishing of the historical capital was not worth the investment. A third factor was that the regime and its forces would have quick access to volatile insurgent areas such as the Shan, Chin, and Karen states. This scenario seems unlikely because of the diminishing threat from ethnic and